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For all that he tried to strangle him, Akbar must have been impressed with Man Singh. Soon afterwards, he put the Rajput prince in charge of an expedition to Mewar. Udai Singh, the man who outsourced the defence of Chittorgarh – and, indeed, of Ranthambore – had died; and Akbar hoped that his successor, Rana Pratap, might be persuaded to submit. Gujarat, meanwhile, was parcelled out, once again, to various chiefs, though now they all served the Mughal court – with Akbar's milk brother Aziz keeping an eye on them from Gujarat's capital, Ahmedabad. Akbar returned to Fatehpur.

Shaikh Salim Chishti, whose prayers had delivered Akbar's sons, and whose village, as a result, was engulfed by the grand stone buildings of Akbar's new capital, was there to greet him. There was another shaikh, too, in the welcoming party; a shaikh whose own son, Abul Fazl, would do as much as, if not more than, Akbar's heirs to keep the padishah's name and authority alive over the centuries. Abul Fazl was yet to join Akbar's court, however; his father, Shaikh Mubarak, had come alone – and determined, it seems, to make a mark. Like everyone gathered to welcome Akbar home, Shaikh Mubarak, too, offered congratulations. His compliments, however, were from God: a message from 'the unseen world' as Abul Fazl would write, one day – to say that Akbar would become 'the Peshwa [leader] of the spiritual kingdom'. It was a sign of things to come that Akbar did not brush aside the overblown praise, but rather enjoyed 'this wondrous congratulation . . .'

He may have forgotten about it, though, in the more temporal satisfaction that was soon to come: Mirza Ibrahim's head.

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The ambitious Timurid had left Gujarat in a fury, a 'rook on a cleared chess-board . . . plundering and ravaging the towns on his way'.[40] His luck, however, much like Ali Quli's, had run out. He found no support in Rajasthan, was chased and beaten most of his way north, his horse shot down from under him at one point, so Mirza Ibrahim had to escape 'on foot through the mire and blood'.[41] In Punjab, the Mirza was wounded by fishermen while resting by a lake. He was injured, friendless and travelling